

3.4 The Thirty-Minute Excavation Sprint

Complete this sprint once per character. Total time: thirty minutes. You will produce one complete seven-layer profile.

3.4.1 Sprint Session Prep Checklist

- ☐ Blank document open (one per character you plan to profile)
- ☐ Timer set for thirty minutes
- ☐ Voice Filter checklist visible (the four-gate question from section 3.3)
- ☐ AI tool closed for now (you will open it during the stress-test phase)
- ☐ Permission granted to yourself: this draft does not need to be perfect

3.4.2 Thirty-Minute Layer Pacing Guide

Time Block	Layer	Focus	Target
0:00–4:00	Layer 1: Surface Mannerisms	Observable speech tics and habits	5–8 traits
4:00–8:00	Layer 2: Communication History	The "why" behind each mannerism	5–8 traits
8:00–12:00	Layer 3: Emotional Defense Mechanisms	Tactical speech shifts under threat	5–8 traits
12:00–16:00	Layer 4: Relational Triggers	Pressure points that break or intensify voice	3–4 triggers with conditional rules
16:00–20:00	Layer 5: Core Wounds	The belief, the cost, the linguistic fingerprint	1 wound belief + 3–4 speech effects
20:00–24:00	Layer 6: Aspirational Self-Image	The mask and the linguistic choices that maintain it	3–4 mask behaviors
24:00–28:00	Layer 7: Hidden Contradictions	The breaking point and the linguistic inversion	1–2 contradictions with example lines
28:00–30:00	Read-back	Read the full profile aloud. Does the voice emerge?	Confirm or flag

Momentum rule: If the timer catches you mid-layer, finish the sentence you are writing, mark the spot with a bracket, and move to the next layer. Forward motion matters more than completion of any single entry.

3.4.3 Side-by-Side Voice Contrast Check

After profiling both lead characters, place the profiles side by side and confirm they occupy distinct linguistic territory.

Dimension	Grumpy Hero	Sunshine Heroine	Distinct? (Yes / No)
Default cadence	[E.G., "Clipped fragments, abrupt stops"]	[E.G., "Run-on sentences that accelerate"]	[Yes / No]
Vocabulary register	[E.G., "Monosyllabic, blunt"]	[E.G., "Effusive, intensifier-heavy"]	[Yes / No]
Sentence-length pattern	[E.G., "2–4 words, then one controlled 15-word sentence"]	[E.G., "Long, tumbling, rarely under 20 words"]	[Yes / No]
Emotional default	[E.G., "Guarded, controlled, cold"]	[E.G., "Open, warm, anxious underneath"]	[Yes / No]
Conversational rhythm	[E.G., "Interrupts, deflects, exits early"]	[E.G., "Fills pauses, asks before answering, overexplains"]	[Yes / No]
Core wound expression	[E.G., "Apologetic brevity in requests"]	[E.G., "Questioning undertone in every statement"]	[Yes / No]
Contradiction signature	[E.G., "Formality collapses to childlike fragments under fear"]	[E.G., "Verbal abundance goes flat and monosyllabic under true hurt"]	[Yes / No]

If any row reads "No," return to that layer in one or both profiles and sharpen the distinction.

3.4.4 Profile Save and Label Protocol

- ☐ File name follows this format: **[CHARACTER_NAME] – Voice Profile – [DATE]**
- ☐ File is stored in a dedicated project folder (not buried in Downloads or Desktop)
- ☐ You can locate and open the file in under ten seconds
- ☐ You have a second copy backed up (cloud drive, secondary folder, or version-control system)
- ☐ You have noted the file location somewhere you will see it when you open Chapter 4